

COMMUNICATION SKILLS: LECTURE No.1

Module 1

Lecture 1

Introduction to Effective Communication

Course Introduction



Hello everybody! Welcome to NPTEL's course on communication skills. You are here on the first module of this course and this is the first lecture. The course comprises twelve modules which are dealt with in forty lectures. The detailed contents of this course (distributed across modules and lectures) are given below.

Sl. No.	Module	Lecture	Topic
1	I	1	Introduction to Effective Communication
2	II	1	Barriers to Communication
3	II	2	Overcoming Strategies

4	II	3	Miscommunication
5	III	1	Non-verbal communication
6	III	2	Non-verbal communication
7	III	3	Non-verbal communication
8	III	4	Non-verbal communication
9	III	5	Non-verbal communication
10	IV	1	Listening Skills
11	IV	2	Listening Skills
12	IV	3	Listening Skills
13	V	1	Letter-Writing
14	V	2	Job application letter
15	V	3	Bio-Data
16	V	4	CV Resume
17	VI	1	Report Writing
18	VI	2	Report Writing
19	VII	1	Group Discussion
20	VII	2	Group Discussion
21	VII	3	Group Discussion
22	VIII	1	Interview Skills
23	VIII	2	Interview Skills
24	VIII	3	Interview Skills

25	VIII	4	Interview Skills
26	VIII	5	Interview Skills
27	VIII	6	Interview Skills
28	VIII	7	Interview Skills
29	IX	1	Netiquette
30	IX	2	Netiquette
31	X	1	Oral Presentation
32	X	2	Oral Presentation
33	X	3	Oral Presentation
34	XI	1	Cross cultural communication
35	XI	2	Cross cultural communication
36	XI	3	Cross cultural communication
37	XI	4	Cross cultural communication
38	XII	1	Common Errors
39	XII	2	Common Errors
40	XII	3	Common Errors

Course Introduction and Description of Lecture Plan

As the table above indicates, the course contents are distributed over twelve modules. Each module consists a minimum of one to a maximum of five lectures, and in total, the twelve modules amount to forty lectures. The focus of this course is on *communication skills*, which cover the four major language skills, namely, **reading, writing, listening, and speaking**. In *Module I*, I talk about *Introduction to Communication and the Need for*

Effective Communication. In the following module, *Module II*, I talk about *Barriers to Communication* and *Overcoming Measures to these Barriers to Communication*. You will come to know of those barriers and obstacles, which actually cause impediments to effective communication. In *Module III*, after introducing you to the operative principles communication, its effectiveness, and then various associated concepts on overcoming the barriers to communication, I will be focusing on *Non-Verbal Communication* with detailed descriptions of *Body Language*. This module highlights the *soft skills* relevant for performing well in professional activities like group discussion and interviews. *Module IV* deals with *Listening Skills* and answers in detail the following questions: Why do we need listening skills? How to enhance our listening skills? How to be a better listener? How to be an *active* listener?

In *Module V*, the focus is on *Written Communication*. Here *Letter Writing*, with special emphasis on *Job Application Letter*, is dealt with. In *Module VI*, the focus is on *Technical Writing* emphasizing *Report Writing*, and highlighting the *difference between literary style and technical style*. The next two modules are quite important in a professional sense. *Module VII* deals with *Group Discussion* covering such issues as: Why group discussion? How to be a good participant in group discussion? How to judge group discussion participants? How to consider the non-verbal aspects of group discussion?

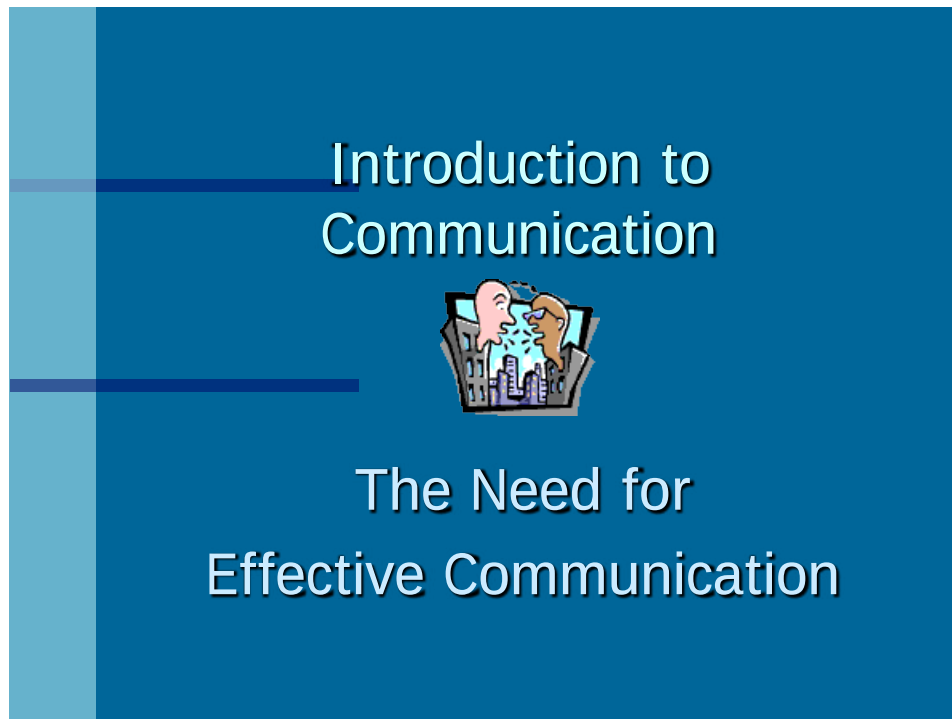
Interview Skills, the next module of consisting of seven lectures, is the longest one in this course. Beginning with a discussion on *how to prepare for an interview*, the module systematically covers all the skills needed for giving a successful performance at an interview. *Module IX* deals with what is contemporary and necessary, that is, Netiquette—the manner and method of expressing oneself on line. The next module, *Module X*, focuses on Oral Presentation. This includes professional presentation skills and general skills related to public speaking. It addresses important questions such as: “How to overcome stage-fright” and “How to deliver a confident presentation.”

Module XI addresses a quite contemporary and relevant topic, that is, *Cross-Cultural Communication* or *Inter-Cultural Communication*. This focuses on communication across-cultures or communication between two cultures. Today, India has become a multi-cultural country, and, in a globalized scenario, there is no country that has a single culture. In this context, interaction with people of another country, or for that matter, with citizens of the world, calls for an informed knowledge of various cultural aspects embedded in the process of communication. Ignorance of the nuances of the cultural import in communication can act as an impediment to effective communication. Hence, the module deals with communication from a global perspective and suggests how one ought to be open to the cultural imprints people carry within themselves. Finally, to make communication smooth and flawless, one needs to look into various practical aspects like grammar, spelling, pronunciation, and punctuation. That is why, the errors that will come

under the practical aspects of communication are kept under one umbrella term *Common Errors*.

After this brief description of the course, I hope you are able to get a bird's eye view of it. All said and done, the sole aim of the course is to make you a very effective communicator. In fact, all of us are equipped with basic communication skills. If you do not have any basic sense of communication, you would not be interested in going through this material! Since you already possess some basic knowledge of communication, you are further interested in enhancing your communication skills. Yet, the principal question remains: Will you be an *effective communicator*? If you want to be an effective communicator, what should you do? And this is the basic question that I raise in this lecture, and I am going to give you answers through various ways and methods. Sometimes, I am not going to give direct answers. On such occasions, I want you to think over some of the issues that I am talking about and come to your own conclusions on the issues.

Read, think, introspect, reflect, practice, build confidence, practice more, seek feedback and act on it—soon you will become an effective communicator!



To begin with, let me ask you a simple question: What is communication? When I ask you this question, think of what comes to your mind immediately. It may bring to your mind an interesting *conversation* you had with your friend about the movie (s)he

watched. You may think of it in this context communication as *sharing of ideas*. True, communication implies *sharing* or *exchange* of thoughts, ideas, and information between two or more people. When you hear an announcement being made about the arrival of a train at a railway station, communication is happening by way of passing *information*. Similarly, when the teacher teaches a lesson to you in the classroom, she is *imparting knowledge* by way of communication. I am communicating with you right now when you are reading this line—I am also trying to *share* with you the *knowledge and information* I have about imbibing communication skills. What is significant here is the *commonness* that is implied in all aspects of communication.

Interestingly, the word **communication** originates from the Latin *communicare* and the French *communis*, both of which mean, ‘common.’ From this information about the origin of the word, we can note the importance given to the aspect of ‘commonality’ in communication. Other related words as ‘commune,’ ‘communicate,’ ‘communion,’ and ‘community’ have the ‘common’ nature implied in them. To make communication effective, one should give emphasis to the *commonality* involved in any interaction. By commonality, I mean the sense of camaraderie or mutuality that is involved in a communication that makes any interactive context a win-win situation and facilitates smooth flow of communication. Commonality principle in communication contributes to *unity, harmony, cohesion, and sharing of aims with team spirit*.

However, generally when we talk about communication, we use it as a very loose and vague term. We mean communication in an ordinary sense but we actually do not mean *effective communication*. Communication in an ordinary sense means getting our basic functions fulfilled through the use of language and communication strategies. For instance, in our everyday life we interact with vegetable sellers, milk vendor, newspaper distributors, etc. However, effective communication happens when you are able to achieve positive results using communication to express your desired goals. This means getting a huge project sanctioned by way of an effective written proposal and oral presentation. Or, at a personal level, it means winning the heart of a beautiful girl / handsome boy through an impressive proposal. That is why you should aspire not to be merely a communicator, but an *effective* communicator. And hopefully, as I said, the course is going to give you sufficient materials in building up your communication skills, and make you a very effective communicator.

Look at this quote: “He who communicates is he who leads.”

Look at this . . .



He who
Communicates
IS
He who leads



The person, who is able to communicate, is the person who is going to lead. Lead in the sense of a *leader*, an *entrepreneur*, a *head*—a person who is able to *take decision*, *influence people and get things done smoothly*. (S)he is the one who is going to be in charge of affairs, and (s)he is the one who is going to lead because (s)he knows how to communicate. All of us can lead, if only we are willing to understand and apply the technical knowhow of effective communication.

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF COMMUNICATION

The success of a leader, manager, teacher, or any professional depends on his/her ability to communicate. Success is directly proportionate to one's ability to communicate. Communication failures, especially in a professional context, are very costly because it can affect productivity. When a higher officer fails to communicate his views to the subordinates, it can lead to ill feeling among the workers, causing strikes, limiting production and subsequent closing of the factory. A manager should especially understand the fact that people will give their best only if the communication is clear. The workers should clearly know what are their work obligations, goals to attain, and terms of reward and punishment. This will help them to relate their goals with the organizational goals and perform effectively.

Okay, now let's look at communication from another perspective. Look at this quote—

Just think about this...

“Half the world is filled with
people who have something to
say and cannot say it
and the other half, of people
who have nothing to say
and keep on saying it”



Robert Frost

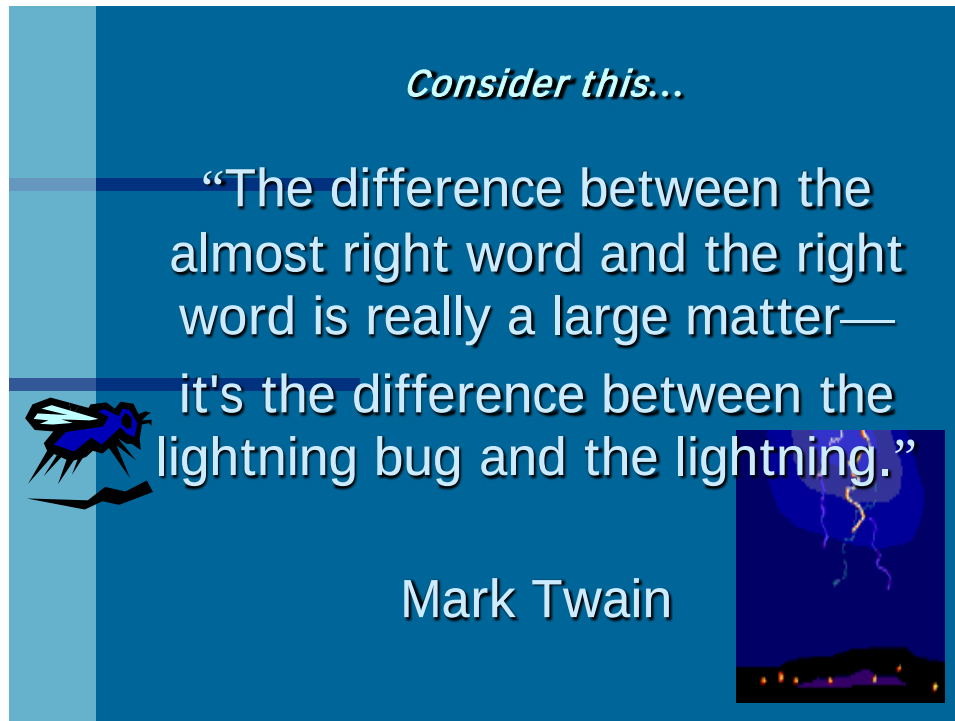
Isn't it funny and interesting? According to Robert Frost, we can divide the entire world into two categories. The first category refers to the resourceful intellectuals, the elites, who have lots of ideas—ideas that can actually rule the world if only they are shared properly. Unfortunately, even resourceful people fail to deliver their contents because they are not able to communicate properly. There are fascinating ideas, path-breaking thoughts, and revolutionary concepts which remain unexpressed. In the second category, we find another large group of people who know nothing—no new ideas, no originality, no creativity—but they keep on saying something thinking that they are *communicating something*. In fact, it will only be senseless and ineffective communication. It reveals the poverty of ideas prevailing among such people.

However, the proliferating channels of communication have shrunk the world into what Marshall McLuhan terms a *global village*. Today, just like in a village, we are able to talk to people from one side of the world to the other side effortlessly. Just by the touch of a button on your mobile phone or laptop you get connected to thousands of people through social networking sites like Facebook or simply by use of email. Nevertheless, when you connect to the other person just at the touch of a button, you tend to think that communication is so easy that you can communicate anytime, anyhow, anywhere with anybody. But the profound question is: Is it always effective? When you communicate so much on Facebook for instance, or when you talk so much on your mobile, have you fully communicated your message? Why is it that after sending so

much of SMS/e-mail messages the sender realizes that the receiver has not understood much of what he wanted to convey? Just think about it . . .

Consider the following from a famous American novelist, Mark Twain:

The difference between the almost right word and the right word is really a large matter – it's the difference between the lightning bug and the lightning.



There is enormous difference between the flickering light emitted by the lightning bug and lightning itself. Knowing the difference between the *almost* right word, and the *right* word, amounts to being *just* a communicator and an *effective* communicator. You might think that there is no harm in using a *substitute* word, a word (synonym) with a similar meaning. But synonyms do not have the *same* meaning. There are subtle differences and shades of meanings even when you use synonyms. For instance, you can say that *the girl looks beautiful*, but you cannot say that *the boy looks beautiful*. You need to say that *the boy looks handsome*. Therefore, *handsome* and *beautiful* may be synonymous with each other but they are used in different contexts. Such knowledge of usage distinguishes one as an effective communicator. So, Mark Twain was trying to tell you in an effectively witty manner that you should always learn to use the right word instead of compromising for the *almost* right word.

Most of you may think that as far as you are able to meet your basic communication needs such as ordering food items on phone, following class lectures, you do not need to strain to become an effective communicator. But by looking at some of the following

examples of miscommunication, you will agree with me that being an effective communicator is important in all aspects of communicative contexts. Look at the following example:



This young boy, in order to give an impression that he is knowledgeable person, he tells her that her father's *genes* can cause her diabetes—implying that she could inherit the disease from her father. To the contrary, the girl found the boy stupid because she heard everything right except the word *genes*, which she heard as *jeans*. Hence, she said: “Stupid! I don’t wear my father’s jeans! How will I get diabetes?”

Let us closely analyze another situation in which communication fails miserably despite so much of verbal exchange. It’s an interesting courtroom situation where the judge interviews a woman before granting her divorce.

Who wants the divorce?

- A judge was interviewing a woman regarding her pending divorce, and asked, “What are the grounds for your divorce?”
- She replied, “About four acres and a nice little home in the middle of the property with a stream running by.”
- “No, I mean,” he continued, “What are your relations like?”
- “I have an aunt and uncle living here in town, and so do my husband’s parents.”

Who wants the divorce?

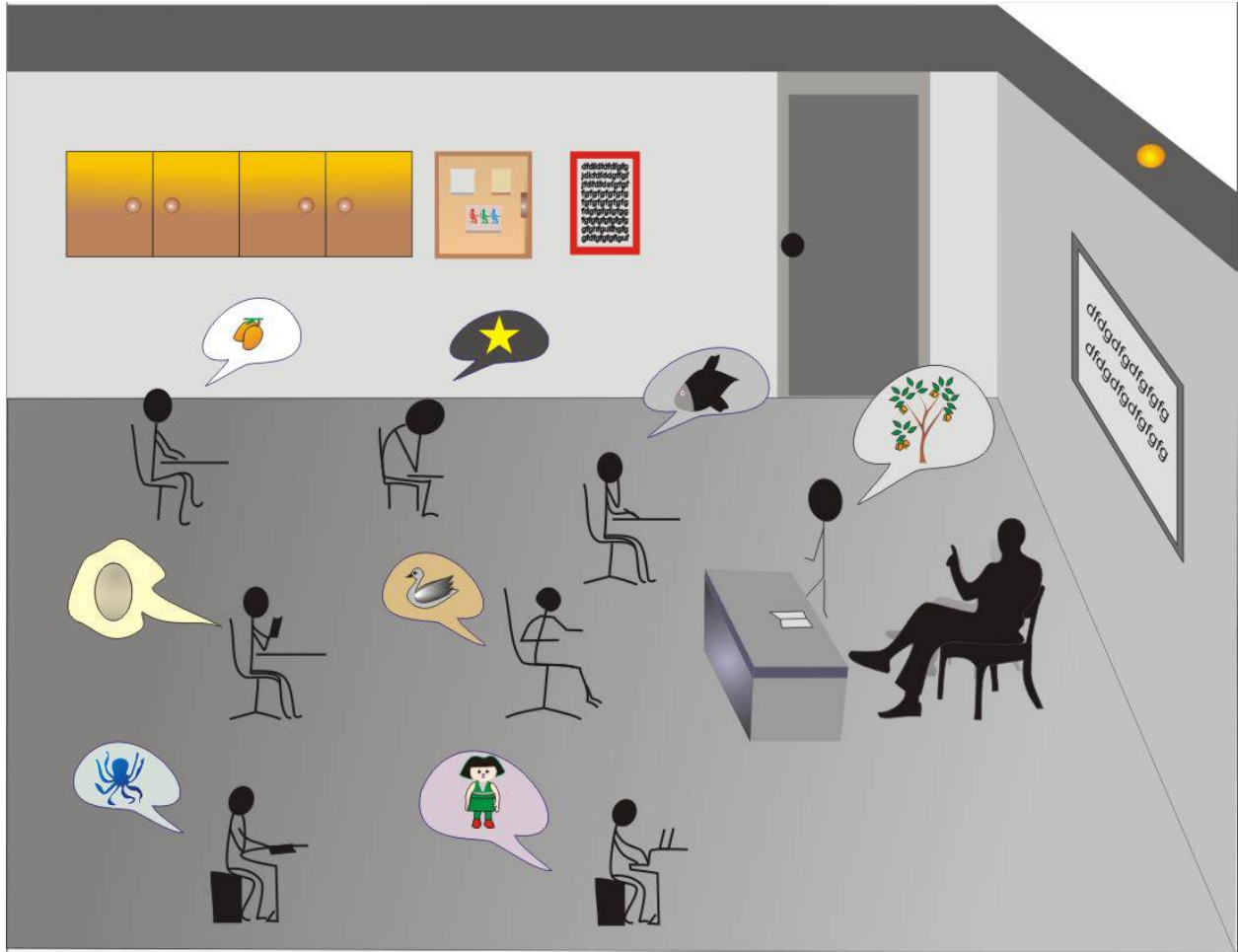
- “Ma’am, does your husband ever beat you up?”
- “Yes,” she responded, “about twice a week he gets up earlier than I do.”
- Finally, in frustration, the judge asked, “Lady, why do you want a divorce?”
- “Oh, I don’t want a divorce,” she replied. “I’ve never wanted a divorce. My husband does. He said he can’t communicate with me.”
- <http://www.thehumorsource.com/item/33064>

The woman has come for a divorce; yet, she is not really interested in it. It is her husband, due to this woman’s poor communicative abilities, who sees no point in continuing to live with her, insisted on a divorce. What went wrong in this case? Lack of effective communication. Who is the culprit? The culprit, of course, is language itself that functions in a very ambiguous way. Language has denotative, connotative, and

contextual meanings. That is, what a word literally means (denotative) may be different from what it connotes (figurative and/or contextual). Thus, “grounds” in the above anecdote has two possible meanings. One, factors forming a basis for action or the justification for a belief, which, the judge meant. The other meaning that the lady inferred was in the sense of a land, an area of enclosed land surrounding a large building. Contrary to what the judge expected, she started describing the grounds that she is surrounded by and that she possesses. Similarly, when the judge asked about “the relations” in the sense of the *relationship* between the husband and the wife, the woman understood as *relatives*. Moreover, by the word “beat,” the judge wanted to know whether the husband was physically beating her. But the woman considered beating as winning in a competition. Thus, in her opinion, her husband beats her up in the competition of getting up early in the morning.

Just ponder over these questions: Can anyone really communicate with the woman? It looks like the woman seems to be desperately misunderstanding or taking the other meaning that is always possible. Is communication only about speaking? Why can’t communication be effective here? Is the husband purely judging his wife only on the basis of what she spoke to him? Was he not a good listener? Was listening not a part of communication? Is it not imperative that if you want to become a good communicator, you should be a good listener? Soon, you will get answers to these questions when I discuss with you about barriers to communication, significance of non-verbal communication and active listening.

Look at the following picture carefully which demonstrates how communication is a complex interactive process.



As illustrated in the above picture, the teacher has asked a girl to describe an object (a tree with some fruits) by action and words without revealing its name. Only through the description, the audience, her classmates, should get the name of the flower. However, if you closely observe the above picture and look at what they get in their mind, none of them are able to get what she is trying to tell exactly. The closest one may be the small tree, yet, it is not a flower. The other ridiculous examples are that they are able to get the number but not the exact object. So, someone thinks of an octopus and others even think of aero-plane and fish.

Hence, I would like to emphasis here that communication involves shared assumptions, and unspoken agreement between individuals. So frequent errors and misunderstandings are quite possible, so we cannot blame the lady (in the previous example) entirely responsible for the situation. We cannot blame even the boy and the girl involved in the genes/jeans dialogue because the aspect of communication has its own ambiguity and problems. We will look deeply into the inherent ambiguities in language and communication when we go to study the *Barriers of Communication*.

Right now, let me look at the communication issue from the way human beings perceive success. How do you define success? What is success anyway? Is it just money to buy expensive cars? Suppose you are able to buy the most expensive car in the world—are you successful? Does success mean getting married to the most attractive person? Or is it just living in a luxurious bungalow? Or your ability to fly on a chartered flight? We can make a long list like this. The answer is, yes and no. Yes, it will amount to success, if you look at that from a purely materialistic point of view; but no, if you look at it from a communication angle. Success, in terms of communication, means your ability to cause the *intended* and *favourable* response.

Success . . .

- **Is your ability to cause the intended and favourable response**
- **The ability to influence people their ideas and thought patterns which govern their actions—gives you sustained success in all walks of life.**

So, success lies in your ability to use communication in a *persuasive* manner. That is, if you propose to a girl, the girl should be responding to you in a favourable manner owing to your ability to communicate clearly and succinctly. If you give a presentation of a very huge project and the persons who are supposed to fund your project should be able to give you the money or even more than the money you want without any hesitation. Success is the ability to influence people, using communication skills, their ideas and thought patterns which govern their actions. Communicative ability to influence people will give you sustained success in all walks of life.

This course on *Communication Skills* aims to close any communication gap that leads to miscommunication. This will be taught to you through various aspects of communication with an overall emphasis on the need for effective communication.

Human beings are social animals owing to their gregarious nature. They tend to live in groups and spontaneously share his thoughts and ideas with others. Today, in this information age, human beings are to be considered *communication animals*. Why? Communication has become so vital for his survival. So much so that the stringent punishment to a human being given is isolation. The worst criminals are kept in solitary confinement bereft of human communication.

We communicate all the time; from the time we get up, the time we go to our school or office, till the time we sleep. Even while sleeping, by snoring, we communicate strongly to people who lie next to us! Communication has become the basis of our lives; it surrounds us, protects us, changes us, reveals us, identifies us, makes us happy, and makes us feel sad. We are just permeated, penetrated by the media of communication. Communication through mobile and the internet has become part and parcel of human life. We communicate our thoughts and feelings to family, friends, co-workers, and friends every hour of every day, but the question that is—do we communicate effectively?

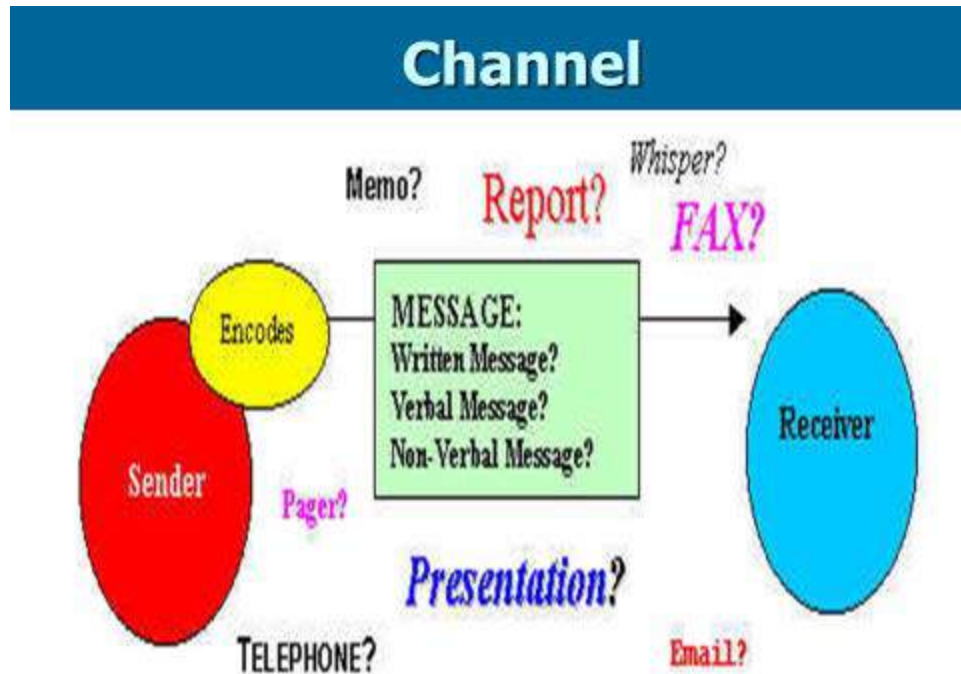
Now, look at this example, what happens if you communicate ineffectively, what is the result of ineffective communication? Here is a person who ordered for a spicy chicken for his dinner. But after the delivery what he got was not what he thought because what he said probably was not heard correctly on the phone and what he got was the chicken that was spiky, not spicy. Moreover, he wanted cooked chicken, to which, he got a live one. So he had to go back to the shop and quarrel with the owner!

After delivery!

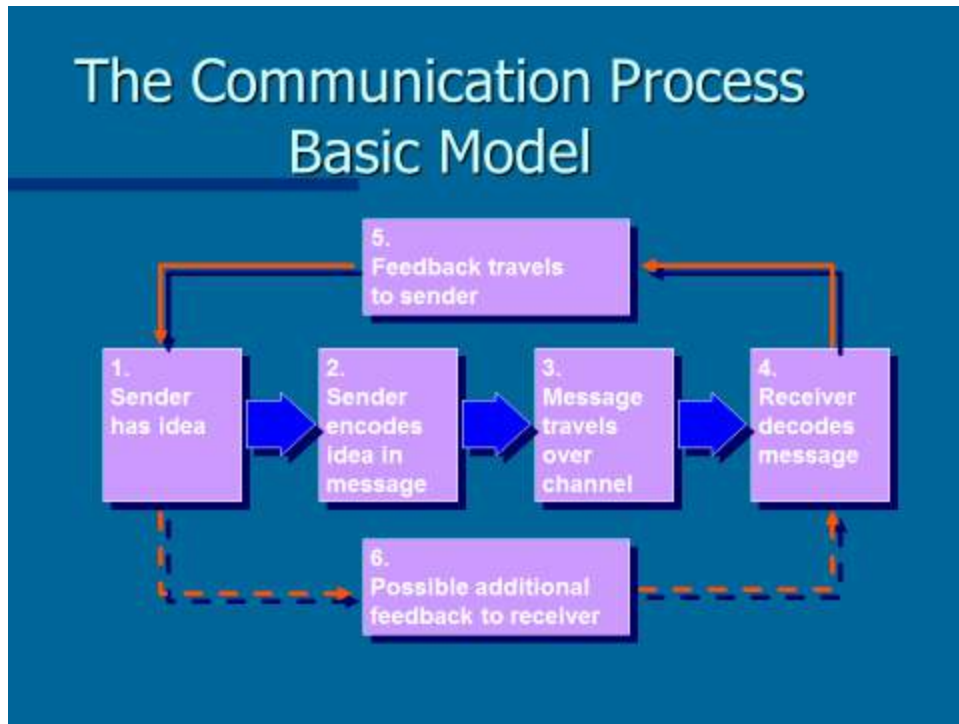


In the coming lectures, you will learn how to overcome this kind of ineffectiveness in communication. At this stage, I can say that if the sender bothered to say it clearly, probably by spelling the word, or if the receiver noted down what he heard and sought for clarification, it would have contributed to effective communication. Now I hope you understand why effective communication is so important? Because, as you realize, ineffective communication will cause frustration, and can lead to dysfunctional personal relationships, stagnant organizations, and even war between countries. Effective communication is needed for success in interviews, job proposals, business as well as personal proposals. What happens if we cause ineffective communication? Academic performance, family life, professional promotions—all can be affected. A recent survey suggests that difference in communication skills are strong predictors of an individual's success whether in society or at work.

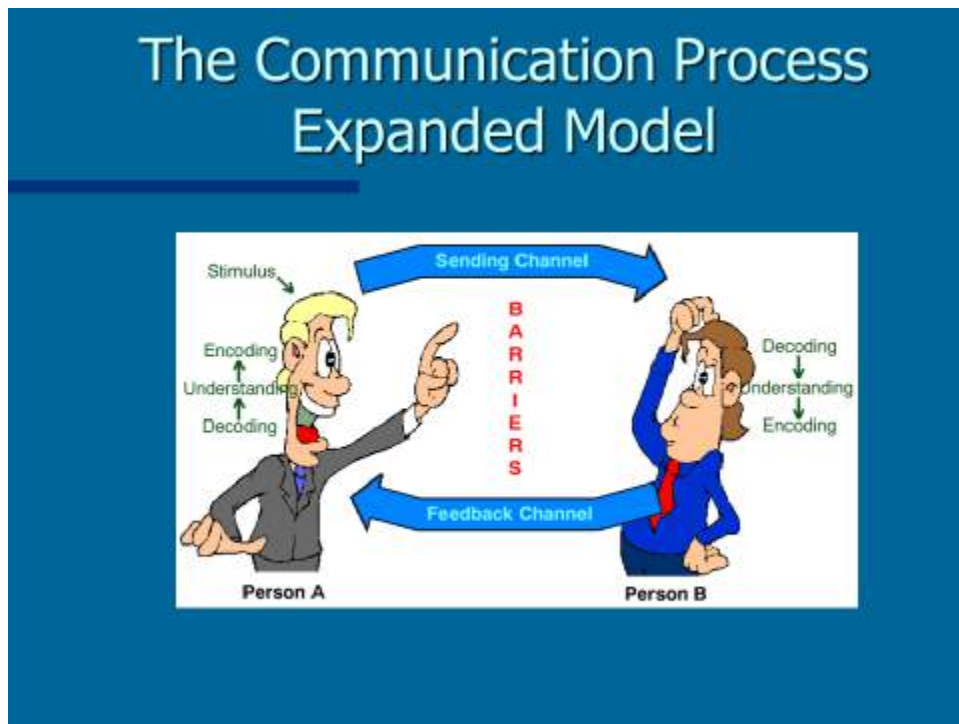
What are the components of communication, and how to use them to make communication effective? In order to answer this question, first let us try to understand the functional aspect of communication. Communication is a two way process. There is basically this *sender*, who sends, or transmits the message, and the other person, who receives the message, is the *receiver*. The transmission is done through a *channel*. The language or code used to convey the message is called *medium*. The receiver sends back a *response*, and the observation of the receiver's response is called *feedback*. For most communication to take place effectively, first and foremost, the channel should be appropriate for the message.



Channel could mean, for example, using email, SMS, hand-written letter, etc. for sending a message. However, appropriate choice of a channel is very important for sending the message. If the correct channel is used, it would help in making the message clear. Certain messages are suitable for sending through e-mail, while some messages are to be conveyed by use of a telephone or face-to-face communication. Before sending the message through a channel to the receiver, the sender *encodes* the message, in written, verbal, non-verbal forms. The receiver decodes the message and sends feedback to the sender. The sender sends back possible additional feedback, to the receiver and completes the communication loop. So this is the Basic Model of Communication:



And if you want to remember it, you can look at this picture, which is an expanded model of communication:



Here, as in the previous model, the sending channel and the feedback channel is used but the aspect that is added here is, stimulus. Without stimulus or motivation the person

lacks desire to communicate. It also puts an emphasis on the understanding process that is involved in between encoding and decoding. If you want to remember the Communication Model in a very simple manner, ask these five W-H questions. Ask the question like: Who sends? That refers to the sender. And then whom does he send? That amounts to the receiver. What does he send? That amounts to the message that is being sent. And then ask the question; “Which medium?”, so that refers to the channel, and then, “to what effect?” implying response or feedback. So in short if you are able to remember this one sentence so you will be able to get the entire communication process, which is: Who sends what to whom through which channel with what effect?

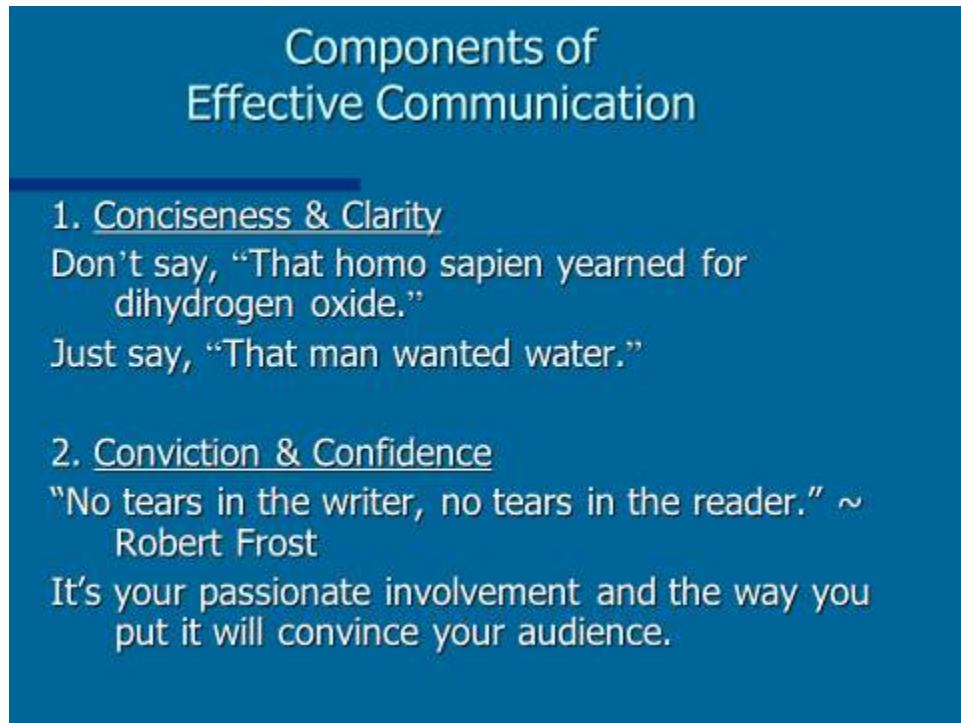
Communication Process
Simple Model: Ask 5 WH questions

- Who sends? *[Sender]*
- Whom does he send? *[Receiver]*
- What does he send? *[Message]*
- Which medium? *[Channel]*
- What effect? *[Response/Feedback]*

***Who sends what to whom through
which channel with what effect?***

Effective communication occurs only when the message and its subtext are fully and completely acknowledged and responded to. Subtext is not what is superficially communicated but what goes within, subtly, with embedded or hidden meanings. Indian hosts, for instance, are remarkable in getting the *subtext* embedded in the communicative messages of their guests. When the host suggests that the guest should have some food, the guest generally refuses to have it though he might be really hungry. With gentle persuasion, the host makes the guest eat something. In addition, the host always looks for hidden meanings from the gesture, the hand and the eye movement, and decodes the message that the guest is very much interested in eating but out of courtesy is saying no. If the subtext is understood, feedback can be given in an appropriate manner. Feedback could be in the form of an acknowledgement, an action, or a verbal or a non-verbal reply. This is the deciding factor in any communication in terms of its effectiveness.

Now let me give quick tips on various components of effective communication.



**Components of
Effective Communication**

1. Conciseness & Clarity
Don't say, "That homo sapien yearned for dihydrogen oxide."
Just say, "That man wanted water."

2. Conviction & Confidence
"No tears in the writer, no tears in the reader." ~
Robert Frost
It's your passionate involvement and the way you
put it will convince your audience.

Look at the first one, it amounts to *conciseness and clarity*. Conciseness is using the right number of words and in the right place. Writing vague sentences, using superfluous words should be avoided. Similarly, simple, instead of, heavy words should be used for clarity. Look at the example: Don't say, homo sapien yearned for di-hydrogen oxide." when you really want to say, "That man wanted water." So, instead of using complicated terms thinking that it will impress the audience, use simple language, be concise and clear in your communication.

Next, you should have conviction and confidence in your communication. Robert Frost says: "No tears in the writer, no tears in the reader." What does it mean? He says that unless you are involved very passionately you will not be able to convince your audience. Hence, you need to have that conviction and confidence to instill the same in your audience.

Components of Effective Communication

3. Genuineness & Interest

Be genuinely interested in the subject matter to cause enthusiastic response from your receiver.

4. Empathy and Timing Sense

Respect your audience; treat them with courtesy & politeness.

Be sensitive to the utility of their time.

Make listening to you a worthwhile experience.

5. Brevity and Effectiveness

"Brevity is the soul of wit." ~ Shakespeare

Be as brief as possible if you want to heighten effectiveness in your communication.

Thirdly, you should be genuinely interested in the subject matter. In order to make it interesting to the audience, you should be enthusiastic about the subject. Further, develop empathy and timing sense while you deliver a communication message. Empathy is feeling into the audience. It means putting yourself into the shoes of your audience to sense what they are thinking about your message. Is it interesting or boring? Do they find it useful or sheer waste of time? Respect your audience, respect their time, treat them with courtesy, and treat them with politeness. If you give a very boring talk, consuming their precious time, with total disregard to their pressing jobs at hand, you actually cause great harm to them. Therefore, you should be always alert and sensitive to the utility of their time. When they come and listen to your talk, you should be thoroughly prepared to convey the maximum message with less amount of words. If you do so, they will feel that listening to you is a worthwhile experience.

Finally, what one should keep in mind is brevity. Shakespeare said, "Brevity is the soul of wit." What he meant by this is that if you really want to be intelligent in your communication, you have to be brief. Be as brief as possible, and that will actually cause effectiveness, because brevity and effectiveness go hand in hand. The more brief you are, more effective you will be.

Now let's look at some types of communication; the basic types being the verbal, and non-verbal, and we are going to discuss these aspects in the coming module. Verbal is the spoken word, the structured language form between two or more entities, dialogues, meetings debates, presentations, which will contribute to the verbal part of

communication. The non-verbal part actually comprises body language, gestures, facial expressions, pictorial representations, pictures, graphs, and sign language.

Types of Communication

- Verbal: spoken word, structured language form between two or more entities; dialogues, meetings, debates, presentations
- Non-verbal: body language, gestures, facial expressions, pictorial representations, sign language
- Communication is more than mere words. To understand a message completely, we have to not only understand *what* is being said, but also *how* it is being said.

Effective Communication is a seamless blend of both verbal and non-verbal aspects of communication

Communication is more than mere words. It is not just either verbal or non-verbal, it is a perfect blend of both. Read more on this topic from the following sources:

For Further Reading . . .

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